

RAVINDRA KISHORE SINHA

57, SECURITY PROVIDER
CHAIRMAN, SECURITY AND INTELLIGENCE
SERVICES
INITIAL INVESTMENT IN 1974 Rs 250
CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 1,600 crore

UNIFORM GROWTH

When intrepid reporter Ravindra Kishore Sinha put his life at stake to sneak into Bangladesh and cover the 1971 war, little did he know that it would eventually pave the way for his Rs 1,600-crore venture, Security and Intelligence Services (SIS). Sinha stayed in touch with many war veterans from the Indian Army, who had become his friends. Many of them, who had retired after the war because of injuries, were looking for jobs. "I wanted to help them but had no idea how to do it," Sinha remembers, ensconced in his fortress-like home in Patna.

In 1974, misfortune came visiting: Sinha's service contract with the newspaper expired, and his employers did not renew it. Sinha was jobless. "This gave me time to look for an alternative career, although I had started working as a freelance journalist," he recalls.

The unemployment, in turn, gave birth to an idea that would change his life for ever. Later the same year, Sinha clinched a contract to provide 11 security guards for a Ramgarh-based factory. He had no money to buy uniforms for the former armymen, who were ready to start afresh. "I asked the Ramgarh factory for an advance, which they readily gave. I got SIS inscribed on the new uniform," he says. Now Sinha needed to set up an office, but he had no money. He finally got an outhouse on rent from an acquaintance, who offered it on the promise of seeking rent only if Sinha made any profit. Luck smiled on Sinha and contracts began pouring in.

In 1988, Sinha set up another office in Ranchi. He shifted the corporate office to Delhi in 1995 and established branch offices in almost all states by 2000. He hasn't stopped at that; Sinha continues to diversify. This year, the SIS tied up with the US organisation, Master Clean, for a foray into the housekeeping business. If the man is to be believed, the list of tie-ups will only grow.

Sinha strongly believes in one-to-one interaction with his employees. Every one of the 30,000-odd SIS security guards has his personal mobile number. "I take their calls. I even call them back after receiving their text messages. Sometimes, they give me business ideas," he says. No wonder, despite its large employee base, SIS is an organisation without a workers' union.

It has been a fairytale experience for Sinha. "At times, I sit silently in astonishment, marvelling at how I did all this," he says. Perhaps to seek an answer he often reaches out to his security guards to give them a pep-talk, his voice soft, yet persuasive, a reminder that power does not need to shout to be heard.

by Amitabh Srivastava



success MANTRA

His indomitable spirit and ensuring "customer delight rather than customer satisfaction"

high POINT

When SIS bought Australia's largest security agency, Chubb Security, for Rs 1,000 crore this year

unforgettable MOMENT

When a station master in Bangladesh saved his life by telling Pakistani soldiers that Sinha was his son-in-law